

The Emerald Isles of the Celts



The emerald isles of the Celts roll green and misty between a silver sea and soft grey skies, dotted with thatched roundhouses, ancient oak groves, and rings of humming standing stones. Mist drifts over still lochs, and across it, just out of sight, lies the Land of Youth where no one grows old. The isles are full of gentle wonders: a playful shapeshifting faerie, a wise old salmon, a shy selkie of the loch, and four children long ago turned into singing swans. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, listens kindly, and keeps a promise. The grandest deeds are done with cleverness and courage and a kind heart, and even a fearsome-seeming stranger, met with a friendly word, often turns out lonelier than it is unkind.



Who's Who and What's What

Places

The Land of Youth - The gentle Otherworld across the mist, once called Tir na nOg, where no one grows old, the apple trees are always in blossom, and a kind heart is the only way in.

The Misty Loch - A still grey lake often wrapped in soft mist, home to the wise salmon and the shy selkie, where a boat may slip across to the Land of Youth.

The Ring of Standing Stones - An ancient ring of tall grey stones on a green rise that hums softly at dawn and dusk, and listens when the swan children sing.

The Roundhouse - The cosy thatched roundhouse at the heart of the village, the heroes' home, with a warm hearth in the middle and stories told around it every night.

The Whispering Oak Grove - An ancient wood of great oak trees where the faeries play, the leaves whisper old secrets, and the winding paths can tangle for anyone without a thread to follow.

Characters

Danu the Kind - The gentle mother goddess of the green isles, who watches over land and loch and smiles on heroes that win by thinking and caring rather than by force.

Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver - The kind old story-weaver of the Roundhouse, who knows every tale of the isles and sends the heroes out with a warm word and a good gift.

Creatures

Pook the Puca - A playful shapeshifting faerie of the oak grove who loves games and surprises, and hands out helpful hints (and the odd harmless trick) to folk he likes.



Sorcha the Selkie - A gentle seal-person of the loch who can slip off her sealskin to walk ashore. She seems shy and a little lonely, but a kind word makes her a steadfast friend who will ferry travellers across the mist.

The Salmon of Wisdom - An old, bright salmon who swims in the misty loch and knows the answer to any riddle. He is fair and kind, and shares a clue gladly with the clever and the gentle.



The Swan Children - Four gentle children turned long ago into white swans, whose evening song lifts the mist and colours the dusk. When their song falters, a grey mist lingers over the loch.

Items

The Ball of Red Wool - A ball of bright red wool. Tie one end where you start and you can always follow it back, however tangled the path becomes.

The Honey Oatcake - A warm, sweet oatcake. Shared with a shy or lonely soul, it can turn a worried frown into a friend.

The Little Harp - A small wooden harp. A simple tune played from the heart can wake the swan children's song and lift the mist.

The Sprig of Oak - A small sprig of oak leaves. A token of friendship that the faeries and the folk of the Land of Youth know and respect.

Words to Know

Cleverness - Quick thinking and a clever plan. In the green isles, a good idea opens doors that force never could, and a riddle is solved with a cool head.

Courage - A steady heart in a misty, scary moment. Courage is not being unafraid; it is being kind and clever even when you are afraid.

Kindness - Care for every soul, faerie or friend. The greatest heroes of the isles are the ones who share, help, and keep a promise.

Idea Bank: The Emerald Isles of the Celts

Improv prompts for the grown-up. When the children want to try something the page did not plan for, reach in here. Nothing is a wrong answer; every idea bends toward warmth, cleverness, and nobody losing.

If the heroes are stuck

- Pook the Puca pops out of a hollow oak as a hare, a hint on his lips, then bounds away laughing.
- The Salmon of Wisdom rises in the loch and breathes a single clue in a ring of bubbles.
- Old Maeve the Tale-Weaver's voice drifts on the wind with the first line of an old tale that holds a hint.
- Let the heroes spend an energy star to "remember a saying their grandmother sang".

Friendly faces to drop in

- A red deer with dew on its antlers who will share the way for a kind word.
- A wren who has lost her nest of moss and could use a hand.
- An old fisherman mending a net who knows where the mist is thinnest.
- A sleepy badger who only wants someone to share an oatcake by the hedge.

Gentle troubles to solve

- A path through the oak grove that tangles unless you lay the red wool.
- A loch wrapped so thick in mist that only a song can lift it.
- A row of standing stones to wake in the right order with a gentle touch.
- A little boat that will only carry those who step in calmly, together.

Ways to win that are not winning

- Make the lonely selkie laugh instead of hurrying past her.
- Trade a honey oatcake for a story rather than for the way through.
- Sing with the swan children until the dusk turns rose and gold.
- Leave the place greener and kinder than you found it.

Celtic flavour to sprinkle

- The smell of peat smoke and rain on heather, the hush of mist over green hills.
- Celtic knotwork on a bronze brooch, a harp by the hearth, an oak leaf for luck.
- The hum of standing stones at dawn, a salmon leaping, swans gliding on grey water.

Stories in this world

Pook's Tangled Paths (young). It is nearly time for the May fair.

The Swan Children's Lullaby (young). Every dusk, four white swans sing a little song over the Misty Loch.

The Journey to the Land of Youth (older). A small friend of the village has gone missing.

Wits and Wonder

World Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Version 2.1, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.